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Kumararama

Kumararama, also known as the **Chalukya Bhimeswara Temple**, is a historic Hindu temple in Samalkota in the Kakinada district of Andhra Pradesh, India.[1] Dedicated to the Hindu god Siva, it is one of the five Pancharama Kshetras, revered pilgrimage sites in the state. The temple houses a 14-foot tall white crystal Siva Linga, which spans two floors, believed to have been consecrated by Kumara Swamy (Kartikeya), giving the temple its name.[2]

The temple is traditionally attributed to the Eastern Chalukya king Chalukya Bhima I, who ruled from 892 to 922 CE.[1] Its architecture reflects the Dravidian style, featuring intricate designs and elements that highlight its historical and cultural significance. Kumararama is a centrally protected monument of national importance and draws devotees from across the region.[3]

Kumararama	
Chalukya Bhimeswara Temple	
Religion	
Affiliation	Hinduism
District	Kakinada
Deity	Siva, Bala Tripurasundari
Festivals	Maha Sivaratri
Location	
Location	Samarlakota
State	Andhra Pradesh
Country	India
Interactive map of Kumararama	
Architecture	
Type	Dravidian
Completed	Early 10th century
Temple	One

Location

The Kumararama Bhimeswara Swamy Temple is situated approximately 1 kilometre from the town of Samalkota. Historical inscriptions in the temple identify the area as Chalukya Bhimavaram in earlier times.[4]

Also located nearby are the Mandavya Narayana Swamy Temple, associated with sage Mandavya, and the Trimukha Lingam Temple, which features a unique three-faced lingam representing the Trimurtulu (Brahma, Vishnu, and Siva).[5][6]

The temple is a part of the Pancharama Kshetras, a group of five prominent Siva temples in Andhra Pradesh.

History

Temple inscriptions

The Chalukya Bhimeswara Temple is traditionally believed to have been established during the reign of Chalukya Bhima I (ruled 892–922 CE), the ruler of the Eastern Chalukyas.[1] Epigraphical evidence, including an inscription at Pithapuram, supports the identification of Chalukya Bhima as the founder of the temple. The inscription says that Chalukya Bhima constructed a shrine dedicated to Lord Siva near Samalkot in Kakinada District. The inscription describes his victories in numerous battles and his 30-year reign.[1]

There is scholarly debate about whether Chalukya Bhima I or II was the founder of the temple. Some scholars, like M. Venkatarangaiya, argue that it was Chalukya Bhima II (ruled 934–945 CE), while others, such as N. Venkataramanayya and B.V. Krishna Rao, identify Chalukya Bhima I as the temple's founder. The presence of a sculptural panel depicting a royal couple at the temple, believed to represent Chalukya Bhima I and his queen, adds weight to the view that he was the founder. Further epigraphical evidence supports this connection, suggesting Chalukya Bhima I was indeed responsible for the temple's construction.[1]

The temple epigraphs refer to the construction of a mukhamandapa at the eastern entrance in 1394 CE. Furthermore, the erection of additional structures, such as the Srimukhamandapam and niluvu mandapam on top of it, is recorded in inscriptions dated to 1422 CE.[7]

Legend

According to Hindu legend, the demon Tarakasura performed intense penance and was granted the Atmalinga as a boon by Lord Siva. Tarakasura also secured an additional boon that he could only be killed by a child, rendering him nearly invincible. Empowered by the Atmalinga, which he placed in his throat, Tarakasura began to terrorize the gods, forcing them to seek refuge with Lord Vishnu. Vishnu advised that only a child born from Siva's divine energy could defeat Tarakasura, prompting the gods to pray to Siva for assistance.[2]

In response to their prayers, Siva created a child, Kumara Swamy (Kartikeya), from his divine energy. Even during his childhood, Kumara Swamy mastered all martial arts and became a skilled warrior. Accompanied by divine forces, he confronted Tarakasura. Realizing that the Atmalinga in Tarakasura's throat was the source of his invincibility, Kumara Swamy launched a powerful attack, shattering the Atmalinga into fragments and killing Tarakasura.[2]

The fragments of the Atmalinga are believed to have fallen at various locations in Andhra Pradesh, where they became the sacred Siva Lingas worshipped at the Pancharama Kshetras. This connection is detailed in the Skanda Purana and Siva Maha Purana.[2]

Architecture

The Bhimeswara Temple at Samalkot shares an architectural resemblance with the Bhimeswara Temple at Draksharamam, showcasing the traditional Dravidian style characterized by six fundamental components. Constructed from robust basalt stone, the temple exemplifies the medieval Chalukyan engineering tradition, where precisely cut stones are balanced using gravity without adhesives. Additionally, the Eastern Chalukyas employed soft sandstone in the construction, combining durability with intricate design elements to enhance the temple's aesthetic and structural integrity.[7]

Temple view from south

Architectural Features

Outer Prakara Walls

The temple is encircled by two prakara walls made of large granite blocks, each measuring approximately 6'×4". The outer prakara wall is notably high, featuring a plain cornice on the exterior and lotus and bead garland decorations on the inner side. Four cardinal entrances, or gopura-dvaras, punctuate the outer wall, each with ardha-mandapas. The northern entrance, now the primary access point, includes a rectangular portico with ornate pilasters and sculptures.[7]

Mandapas and Entrances

The eastern entrance faces a tank with a four-pillared mandapa at its centre. The mandapa, supported by pillars with square bases and octagonal shafts, exhibits exquisite carvings, including lotuses and decorative bands. Similarly, the southern and western entrances mirror the eastern structure but with unique decorative motifs, such as figures of dvarapalakas in dvibhanga poses holding tridents and damarus.[7]

The northwestern corner houses a large mandapa with 66 intricately carved pillars. This includes the Simhapada pillar, notable for its lion-base design. Additionally, the northeastern corner features the "Uyala Mandapa," an engineering marvel that oscillates with minimal force, showcasing the Chalukyan architects' ingenuity.[7]

Inner Prakara and Verandahs

The inner enclosure wall, made of riveted granite blocks, divides the inner and outer sanctums. This wall incorporates pilasters, gables, and simhalalata motifs. Two-story verandahs with rows of pillars surround the main shrine, offering a cloister-like experience. Carved icons of Surya, Vishnu, Saraswati, and others embellish the verandah niches.[7]

Main Shrine

The central shrine, disconnected from the outer structures, is a two-story rectangular edifice measuring 24.6 × 13.9 meters. The lower story serves as a non-functional base, while the upper story houses the sanctum and is used for rituals. The adhisthana features intricate moldings, including depictions of elephants, lions, and floral patterns. The garbhagruha contains a tall octagonal lingam, accessible through a pradakshina patha.[7]

Dhwaja-stambha

The vimana above the sanctum is a two-tiered structure of the Nagara style, recently renovated with plaster. The original design, though obscured, retains elements such as rowed geese, lotuses, and kuta-shalas.[7]

Additional Features

A small stone model of the temple near the southern entrance highlights the artistic expertise of the era.[4] The Tiruchuttumala, a cloistered walkway around the shrine, includes 67 pillars adorned with intricate sculptures of dancers, musicians, and mythical figures.[7]

Devotees visiting the temple first offer their prayers to the upper portion of the Siva Lingam on the first floor and then proceed to worship the base or feet of the Lingam. Inside the temple, there are several sub-shrines dedicated to various deities, including Kala Bhairava, Maha Kali, Veerabhadra, Vinayaka, Saneswara, and the Navagrahas (nine planets). A Nandi (bull) idol, carved on a single stone, faces the Siva Lingam in the garbhagruha (sanctum sanctorum).[2]

A unique feature of the temple occurs during the months of Chaitra and Vaisakha, when the sunlight touches the feet of the deity in the early morning hours and the feet of the goddess in the evening.[2]

Festivals

The Kumararama temple is known for its vibrant celebrations, especially during the months of November and December, which coincide with the Karthika and Margasira months in the Hindu calendar. Daily abhishekas are performed during this period. One of the most important festivals at the temple is the Kalyana Mahotsavvam, celebrated in February–March during the Magha Bahula Ekadasi day.[2] Maha Sivaratri, a major festival dedicated to Lord Siva, is also observed with grand celebrations at the temple.[4]

In popular culture

Kumararama Temple has been featured in several Telugu films over the years. The song "Laloo Darwaja" from *Bommarillu* (2006) was shot at the temple.[8] Additionally, some portions of the film *Karthikeya* (2014) were also filmed at the temple.[9]

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External links

- Kumararama (https://web.archive.org/web/20060630013002/http://eastgodavari.nic.in/Samalkota.html)
- More on Kumararama (http://www.templenet.com/Andhra/bheemarama.html)
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